- They don't understand how a bill becomes a law and don't believe in the process;
- They don't understand how cases get prosecuted and how evidence has to be presented and [how] the different parts of the judicial system operate … checks and balances;
- They don't get how judicial review works to determine constitutionality.

The problem, she argues, is that tech-savvy people tend to look at laws as if they are computer code. In the software world, even a tiny flaw negates a hugely strong premise. Once a bad law is on the books, they believe, it will operate like bad software: mechanically, like a guillotine. So: 'unless every single edge-case, hypothetical, problem is identified, spelled out, and remedied, nothing can stand.'

That is not the way that a modern law-governed society works. Imperfections and hard cases abound. The art of politics and administration is balancing constraints and anomalies in a way that produces the least unfair or dangerous outcomes, now and in the future. That world is messy and sometimes murky. To the self-righteous and impatient it may seem impossible to change. But for all its faults, it is capable of correction. America recovered from the McCarthy era. The Church committee reined in an out-of-control FBI after the abuses discovered in the 1970s. The same is true in other Western countries.

Zealots such as Snowden prefer their own judgment to the outcomes that this flawed, slow, muddled system provides. It is their right to believe this and to act on it—within the law. But their form of protest takes the form of stealing and publishing state secrets, in a way that causes irreversible damage (impact, as they would put it). This is not an approach that would be tolerated in other forms of protest. Anti-nuclear activists may blockade power stations or weapons facilities. Even they would regard it as irresponsible to try to sabotage them,